

BARK

Like the roots, bark carries nourishing properties to the plant. Although bark is not the most commonly used part of a shrub or tree, it is becoming a popular tisane ingredient, with each type of bark imparting unique flavors and health benefits to the infusion.

The inner layers of the bark are a tree's powerhouse, nourishing and sustaining it, while the innermost rings of the trunk give the tree structural support. Improperly harvesting bark will permanently damage the tree, so foraging for it on your own is not advised; it is best to purchase bark that has been harvested from

farmed trees. Whether you intend to consume the bark on its own or with other herbs, you need to prepare it as a decoction (see p145). When using bark with other herbs, infuse the dry herbs in boiling water for at least five minutes before adding the bark decoction.



WILD CHERRY

(*Prunus avium*)

Wild cherry, or choke cherry, bark has a soothing effect on coughs and is therefore used in many commercial cough medicines. It also contains prunasin, which helps to reduce inflammation caused by infection. It has an astringent, sometimes bitter taste, and is best blended with more pleasant-tasting herbs or fruits.

CINNAMON

(*Cinnamomum verum*)

Cinnamon bark's antioxidant properties are used to treat cold and flu symptoms, while its antibacterial properties aid digestion by reducing gas and stimulating appetite. This spice should be taken sparingly as it contains coumarin, a naturally occurring sweet compound that can damage the liver if taken in large doses. There are two varieties of cinnamon: Cassia and Ceylon. Grown in Sri Lanka, Ceylon cinnamon is considered to be superior as it contains less coumarin, making it a better choice for tisanes.

